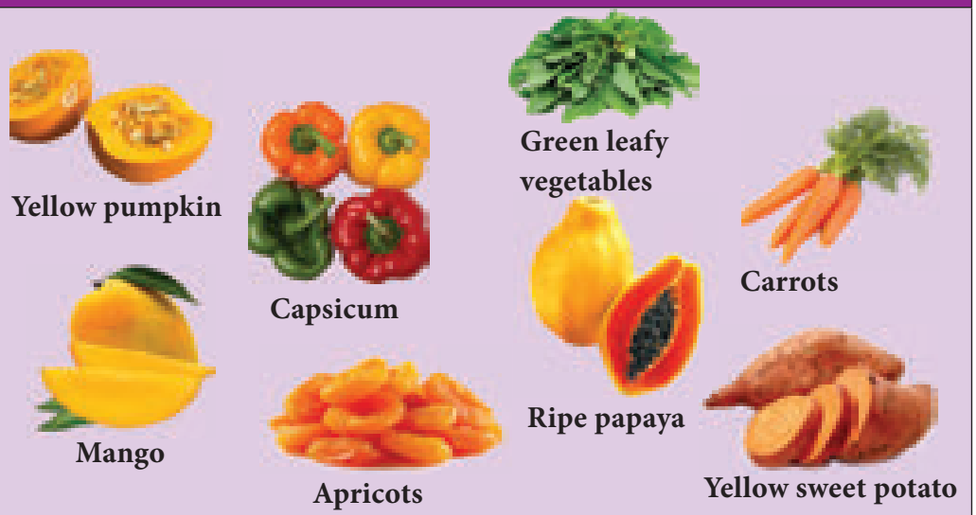
12.11 Role of food in the prevention of cancer

A diet rich in plant - based foods can help lower the risk of cancers. Specific components found in certain plant foods aid in preventing cancer. Here are a few:

1. Antioxidants

A number of free radicals are constantly produced in our body. These free radicals are highly reactive and can damage cellular components such as the cell membrane and DNA. This leads to an increased risk of cancer. Antioxidants play a role in cancer prevention by scavenging these free radicals. Antioxidants are compounds present in fruits and vegetables which help protect tissues from being damaged by the attack of free radicals. Vitamin C, vitamin E, and vitamin A are called antioxidant vitamins. The body cannot synthesize these vitamins and therefore they need to be provided in the diet.

Table 12.1 Foods rich in antioxidant vitamins A, C and E

Vitamin	Food Source
A	 Yellow pumpkin; Capsicum; Green leafy vegetables; Carrots; Mango; Ripe papaya; Apricots; Yellow sweet potato
C	 Amla; Orange; Cabbage; Broccoli; Gauva; Strawberry; Kiwi; Greens; Tomato; Lemon; Blue berry; Capsicum; Pine apple

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